1912), quoted in 'History of Hindu Mathematics' by B. Datta and A. **TV.** *Singh {1935).*

period of nearly five thousand years saw the rise and fall of **many a** civilization, each leaving behind it a heritage of literature, art, philosophy, and religion. But what was the net achievement in the field of reckoning, the earliest art practised by man? **An** inflexible numeration so crude as to make progress well nigh impossible, and a calculating device so limited in scope that **even** elementary calculations called for the services of an e x p e r t . . . . Man used these devices for thousands of years without making a single worthwhile improvement in the instrument, without contributing a single important idea to the system.... Even when compared with the slow growth of ideas during the dark ages, the history of reckoning presents a peculiar picture of desolate stagnation. When viewed in this light the achievements of the unknown Hindu, who sometime in the first centuries of our era discovered the principle of position, assumes the importance of a world event.'*

Dantzig is puzzled at the fact that the great mathematicians of Greece did not stumble on this discoyery. 'Is it that the Greeks